



ANI

# BJP VS CONGRESS

The BJP may have the far stronger presence in Maharashtra, but given the national stakes involved, it is mindful of the Congress revival in the state. The Grand Old Party bagged 13 seats in the Lok Sabha election, four more than the BJP even though its vote share of 16.7 per cent was far less than the BJP's 26.7 per cent (largely due to the Congress contesting fewer seats). The Congress's impressive performance came on the back of SS(UBT) and NCP(SP) support. For the BJP, the real concern is that from a peak of 122 seats in 2014, its tally had dropped to 105 in 2019. In the Lok Sabha election, it was ahead only in 83 assembly segments. For the Mahayuti to win and form the government, the BJP has to win a minimum of 80 seats to remain in the driver's seat and hope the Shinde Sena and Ajit's NCP brings in the remaining 65 to cross the 145-seat majority mark.

A major issue is deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis, once BJP's star leader and a former CM, being forced to play second fiddle to CM Shinde, who has increasingly asserted himself in matters of policy and governance. Fadnavis's image has also

**FOR THE BJP, A CONCERN WILL BE THE FALL IN TALLY SINCE THE PEAK OF 122 SEATS IN 2014. IN THE LS POLLS, IT WAS AHEAD IN JUST 80 ASSEMBLY SEGMENTS**

## Advantage BJP

- The Sangh Parivar is back on board. BJP's famed poll machinery returns to top gear
- Strong local leaders on the ground, including a few turncoats from the Congress
- Falling back on politics of polarisation; hopes news of minority votes coalescing for MVA leads to "reverse mobilisation" of Hindu vote
- Deputy CM Fadnavis goes for makeover, brands himself 'Deva bhau (dear brother)'